

2026-08-30 — The Rosh HaShanah Tefillah: זכרונות, מלכויות, שופרות and the Duality of the Day

Content-based review · reviewer read the transcript, summary, and finished write-up · 30 August 2026

1. The Shiur in One Paragraph

This is the Rav's opening shiur of the Rosh HaShanah machzor arc, delivered by his own admission without full prep — his sefarim are still in boxes — and framed as a wide-lens introduction rather than a granular deep-dive. He opens with the Nadvorna vort ("אתה צריך לסדר את" — המחזור מסודר — במקומו, הסיפור במקומו) and the Baal Shem Tov's fox mashal, both landing the same musar: personal preparation and personal שפלות come before machzor mechanics. He then does what the series always does — asks where the tefillah actually came from. The core claim: אונתנה תוקף is a late piyut, and the true tefillah of Rosh HaShanah is שופרות, זכרונות, מלכויות, פסוקי מלכויות. He walks the historical layers — the Mishnaic ten-pesukim structure (3 Torah, 3 Kesuvim, 3 Nevi'im, 1 Torah), the מחלוקת R' Akiva vs R' Yochanan ben Nuri on where Malchiyos lives, the introductions (עלינו, אתה זוכר, אתה נגלית) תקיעתא דבי רב, and the later Geonic/Rishonic layer of piyutim. The second half pivots to the emotional duality — פחד הדין (Reb Chaim Shmuelevitz's noose-around-the-neck pshat in תלויים ועומדים, Maharsha on מחיה המתים after twelve months) balanced against שמחה ובטחון (Pri Chadash's mishloach manos, the Imrei Emes maisheh, הדוות ה'), synthesized under גילו ברעדה. Closes with Rav Dessler's מכתב letter and the Rebbe Reb Meilech / Reb Zushe switched-beds story to hammer that the גזר דין is a מוחלט.

2.What Was Strongest

- **The core thesis — אונתנה תוקף is not the ikkar; the pesukim are —** is exactly the kind of frame-reset this series does best. The Brisk anecdote (walking into אונתנה תוקף and finding the Rosh Yeshiva flat, then finding him *red-faced* at Malchiyos/Zichronos/Shofros) is a perfect story to sell it. It's the sort of move that will change how a talmid opens the machzor next week.
- **The historical layer-cake —** Tannaim (pesukim only) → תקיעתא דבי רב (thematic hakdamas) → Geonim/Rishonim (piyutim) — is a clean three-tier scaffold that gives the mispallel a mental map for what he's actually holding when he opens the machzor. This is what the series has been training the oilam to think in, and it lands well here.
- **The Nadvorna vort as opener** is well-chosen for a shiur the Rav himself admits was under-prepped — "סדר את עצמך" becomes not just musar but implicit disclosure. It disarms the audience and reframes the whole hour.
- **The Reb Chaim Shmuelewitz pshat in תלויים ועומדים** — literally the noose around the neck, kicking the bucket — is the emotional peak of the shiur. Paired with the Maharsha on מחיה המתים after yud-beis chodesh, it gives real teeth to the פחד half of the duality without being maudlin.
- **The Pri Chadash / Imrei Emes / Sefardi-with-mishloach-manos maisch** is a beautiful set-piece for the שמחה half — one concrete Rishonic-era source (well, Acharon), one modern-era vignette, and the pasuk in Nechemiah tying them together. Textbook Rabbi Ephrati integration of halacha, history, and story.

3. What Was Weaker or Worth Pushing Back On

The shiur was openly unprepared and it shows. The Rav flags it in the first two minutes and returns to it — "my sefarim are still in boxes," "we'll do a more sophisticated shiur next week." The frame ends up being an *introduction to an introduction*, which is fine as a placeholder but leaves the arc without a real anchor for the week the oilam actually starts davening from the machzor. If this is the last shiur before Rosh HaShanah, the audience needed something they could take to the amud, not a promise about next week.

The R' Akiva / R' Yochanan ben Nuri machlokes was under-lomdishized.

The Rav named it, sourced it to Usha, noted that Galil paskened one way and Yehuda the other — and then just moved on to "we pasken like R' Akiva." But the sevara-side of the machlokes is huge: is Malchiyos an independent kiyum of

קדושת היום (R' Akiva), or is it a general מצלכות שמים statement that piggybacks

on קדושת היום של (R' Yochanan ben Nuri)? That is the whole "היה הקדוש

"היה היא מלכות" chiddush the Rav then makes, but it's presented as a Gemara

conclusion rather than a lomdish shitah.

נחמנו תוקף deserved more than a wave-off. The Rav's move — "not the

ikkar, later piyut, big machlokes among historians, we're not talking about it

today" — is defensible pedagogically but leaves a hole. If you tell the oilam their

most-inspiring moment is not the ikkar, you owe them a sentence on *what to*

do with that practically. Say it with less kavana? Skip it? Say it but budget

more kavana for the pesukim? He leaves them theologically demoted and

practically stranded.

The piyutim advice ("don't say them if you don't understand") is a strong

halachic claim delivered casually. The Rav says it twice, once yesterday

and once here. There is a respectable minhag-defense of piyutim-as-avoda-b'lo-

havana that he doesn't engage — the Chida, the Chasam Sofer, and the whole

Ashkenazische tradition of piyutei ha-Kalir as מפילה של אבותינו. He can hold

his position; he just needs to acknowledge that gedolei olam disagreed.

The "you're closer to death than to life" pesukim / kids point was

philosophically strong but oratorically loose. The Rav gets stirred up ("what are we doing to our kids?") and the passage drifts. The point — that modern American Yiddishkeit has softened **מעגליכע** beyond what Chazal intended — is important, but delivered as a rant rather than a structured claim. This is the kind of place a Rav Wolbe or Rav Shlomo Wolbe framing (**אור הצפון** on **צאנה** terror) would have sharpened the message.

4. Halachic / Lomdish Observations

On **קדושת היום Rosh HaShanah being **חלכות**** the Brisker chakira here writes itself and the Rav didn't take it. Is **חלכות שמים** Rosh HaShanah (a) the *content* of the day's kedusha, or (b) a separate kiyum grafted onto the day? R' Akiva's ruling to combine them suggests (a); R' Yochanan ben Nuri's separation suggests (b). The Rambam in Hilchos Shofar and the way he formulates the bracha (**על כל הארץ מקדש ישראל ויום הזכרון**) is worth learning specifically on this.

On the 3+3+3+1 pesukim structure — the Rav explained the sequencing (Torah first, then Kesuvim before Nevi'im because Dovid preceded the Nevi'im, then a Torah closer) but didn't name what's really going on: this is the same **קל** **בנין אב** / **לוגיק** Chazal use throughout Shas — Torah brackets the structure, Kesuvim/Nevi'im fill the middle. Worth naming as a formal Chazal design principle rather than a one-off choice.

On **שמע כעונה and the piyutim skip:** if the Rav is genuinely paskening that a mispallel who doesn't understand should skip the piyutim, the halachic mechanism matters. Is he being yotzei via the chazzan (**שמע כעונה**) Is there no chiyuv at all so nothing to be yotzei? Or is the piyut technically **הפסק** which most poskim were **למסיר** because of long-standing minhag? He should pick a lane.

On **צלי ברעדה synthesis** — the Ramban in Shaar HaGemul and the Nefesh HaChaim (Shaar 3) both address this exact **שמחה** / **הנאה** with the same pasuk, and both offer different resolutions (Ramban: sequential; Nefesh HaChaim: simultaneous via **ענה**) The Rav's "only a Yid can do this" is warm, but there's real lomdish literature on *how* a Yid does it that would strengthen

the point.

On Rav Dessler's letter (מכתב מאליהו) it's worth noting that Rav Dessler's determinism-of-the-**דין** position is not universally held; the Rambam in Hilchos Teshuva 2:6-7 and the Kesef Mishneh's read on **מקרעים גזר** during Aseres Yemei Teshuva are the classical counterweight. The Rebbe Reb Zushe story is beautiful but leans hard in one direction — worth pairing with the mainstream view that **תפילה**, **משובה** and **מאסקה** genuinely reopen the **גזר דין**.

5. Follow-up Questions Worth Asking the Rav

Q1. If **אונתנה תוקף** not the ikkar, what should a mispallel practically do with it? Say it with less kavana? Say it but shift the emotional peak to the pesukim of Malchiyos? Or is the piyut fully legitimate as an **מאגות** that enables the pesukim that follow?

Q2. On R' Akiva vs. R' Yochanan ben Nuri — is the **מחלוקת** about where Malchiyos lives, or is it a deeper machlokes about whether Rosh HaShanah's **קדושת היום** Malchiyos (R' Akiva) or whether Malchiyos is a separate kiyum grafted on (R' Yochanan ben Nuri)?

Q3. The **תקיעתא דבי רב** is Rav establishing a new chiyuv, or codifying an existing minhag? And why did his **מקדמות** (עלינו, אתה זוכר, אתה נגלית) become universal when other Amoraic additions elsewhere in the siddur stayed local?

Q4. On the piyutim-skip advice: is this a formal **מחמיר** the Rav is machmir on, or a musar-based recommendation? Would he pasken this way for a bochur in yeshiva who's still building his machzor-fluency, or only for a working baal habayis?

Q5. On **מגור** tzibbur-protection — is this a formal halachic principle (analogous to **מגילת ציבור אינה חוזרת ריקם**) a Zoharic/Chassidische hashkafa? If halachic, does it change how a yachid davens when there's no minyan on Rosh HaShanah?

Q6. Rav Dessler says the entire year's **מגור** set on Rosh HaShanah. How does that square with the Rambam's mainstream view that **משובה** during

| Aseres Yemei Teshuva can genuinely change the decree? Is Rav Dessler a | דעת
| ת"ר is he describing the same reality in different language?

6. Bottom Line

| *This is a Rabbi Ephrati "under-prep" shiur that succeeds on strength of*
| *framing rather than on newly-marshaled sources — and honestly, that's*
| *fine. The Rav flags the constraint upfront, uses the Nadvorna vort to make*
| *his own | ת"ר the opening move, and delivers a genuine | ש"י-of-*
| *emphasis: that the machzor is a layered artifact and the ikkar is the*
| *innermost layer (Chazal's ten pesukim of Malchiyos/Zichronos/Shofros),*
| *not the outermost (piyutim, including | זנה תוקף). The שמחה/ | פחד*
| *synthesis in the second half is warm, story-driven, and emotionally on-*
| *target for the week before Rosh HaShanah, with Reb Chaim Shmuelevitz*
| *and the Rebbe Reb Zushe story doing real work. The weaker moments are*
| *structural — the R' Akiva/R' Yochanan ben Nuri sugya was flattened, the*
| *piyutim pesak was thrown off cuff, | זנה תוקף got demoted without*
| *a practical replacement — and reflect the Rav's own admission that this*
| *was a placeholder shiur. As a stand-alone it's a solid pre-Yom-Tov drasha.*
| *As the opener of a machzor arc it needs the promised follow-up next week*
| *to redeem the setup.*

Produced by a content-based review pass — the reviewer was given the full transcript, summary, and the finished write-up, and asked to react to the shiur itself (not the write-up). Complement to the Independent Editorial Review.